VICTORY 2027

Treasure Chest : POETRY

When Great Trees Fall

Lecture 1 | ENGLISH

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TOPICS TO BE COVERED

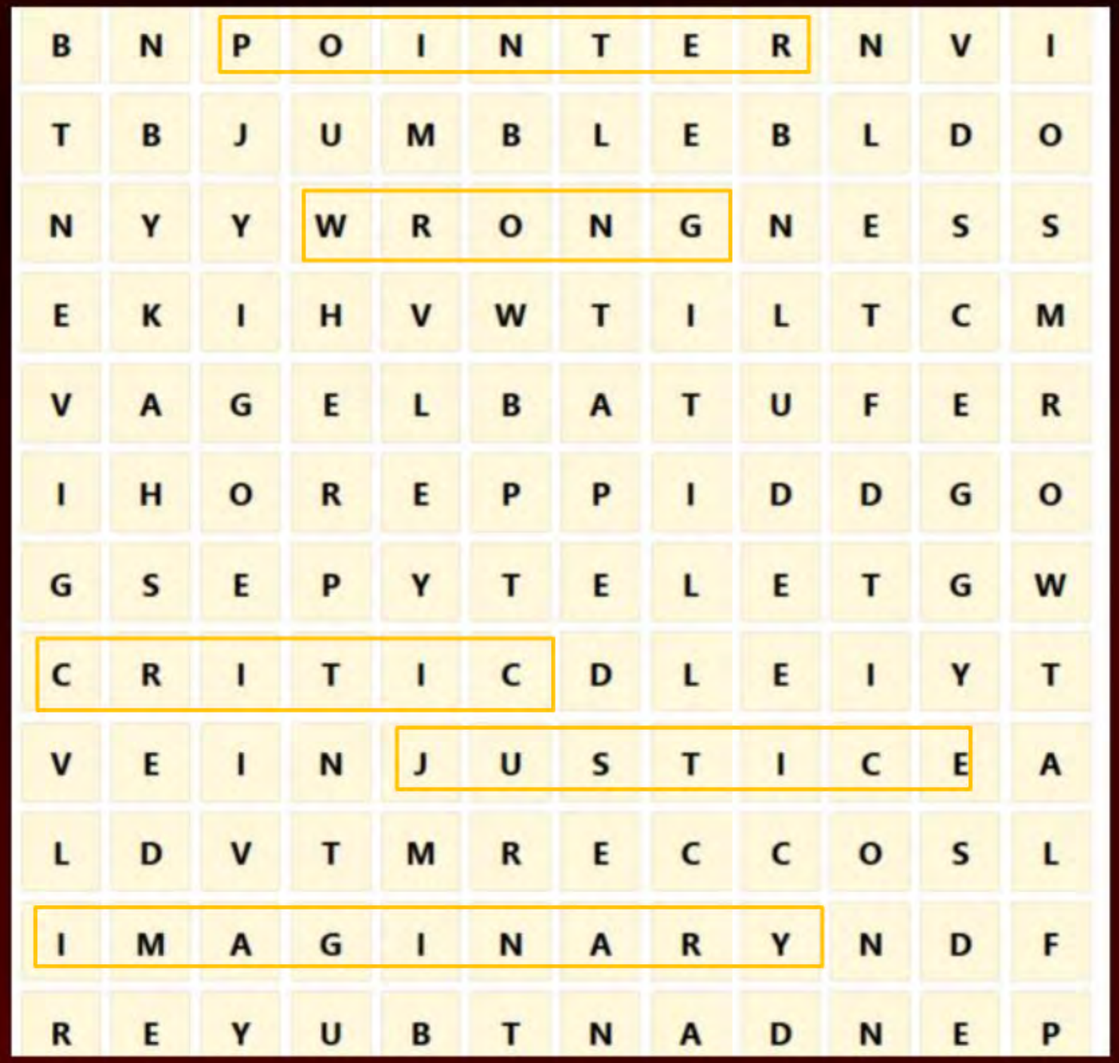
1. Overview
2. Stanza-wise Explanation
3. Poetic Devices
4. Themes
5. Summary

Keywords
Key phrases

PYQs, Specimen Paper 2027, Competency-Based

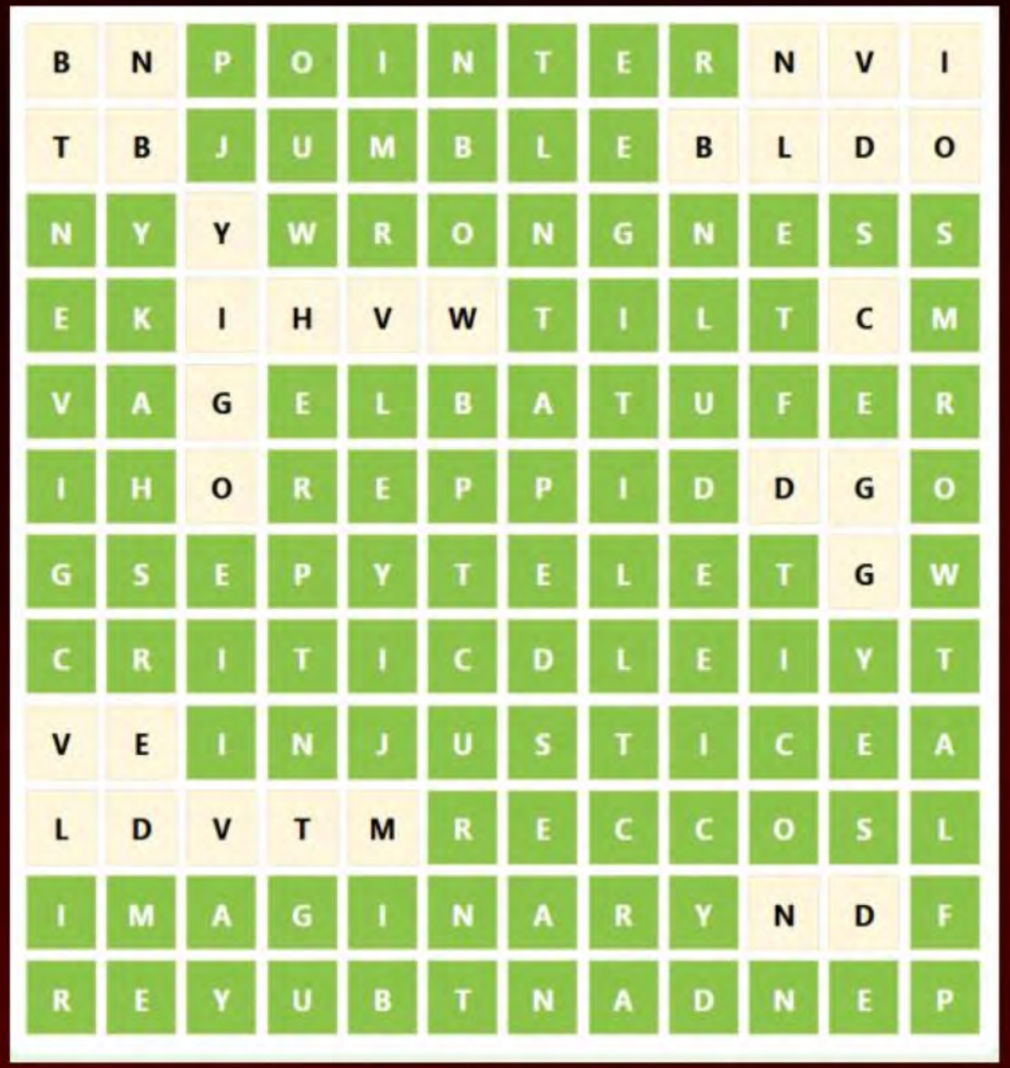


TOPIC: WORD SEARCH



B	N	P	O	I	N	T	E	R	N	V	I
T	B	J	U	M	B	L	E	B	L	D	O
N	Y	Y	W	R	O	N	G	N	E	S	S
E	K	I	H	V	W	T	I	L	T	C	M
V	A	G	E	L	B	A	T	U	F	E	R
I	H	O	R	E	P	P	I	D	D	G	O
G	S	E	P	Y	T	E	L	E	T	G	W
C	R	I	T	I	C	D	L	E	I	Y	T
V	E	I	N	J	U	S	T	I	C	E	A
L	D	V	T	M	R	E	C	C	O	S	L
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R	E	Y	U	B	T	N	A	D	N	E	P

TOPIC: WORD SEARCH



B	N	P	O	I	N	T	E	R	N	V	I
T	B	J	U	M	B	L	E	B	L	D	O
N	Y	Y	W	R	O	N	G	N	E	S	S
E	K	I	H	V	W	T	I	L	T	C	M
V	A	G	E	L	B	A	T	U	F	E	R
I	H	O	R	E	P	P	I	D	D	G	O
G	S	E	P	Y	T	E	L	E	T	G	W
C	R	I	T	I	C	D	L	E	I	Y	T
V	E	I	N	J	U	S	T	I	C	E	A
L	D	V	T	M	R	E	C	C	O	S	L
I	M	A	G	I	N	A	R	Y	N	D	F
R	E	Y	U	B	T	N	A	D	N	E	P

Words to Find

- ~~PENDANT~~
- ~~REFUTABLE~~
- ~~TELETYPE~~
- ~~SHAKY~~
- ~~CRITIC~~
- ~~POINTER~~
- ~~INJUSTICE~~
- ~~TILT~~
- ~~FLATWORM~~
- ~~SOCCER~~
- ~~JUMBLE~~
- ~~WRONGNESS~~
- ~~IMAGINARY~~
- ~~DIPPER~~
- ~~GIVEN~~
- ~~YIELD~~
- ~~BUYER~~

WHEN GREAT TREES FALL

Men Die

Topic: Overview

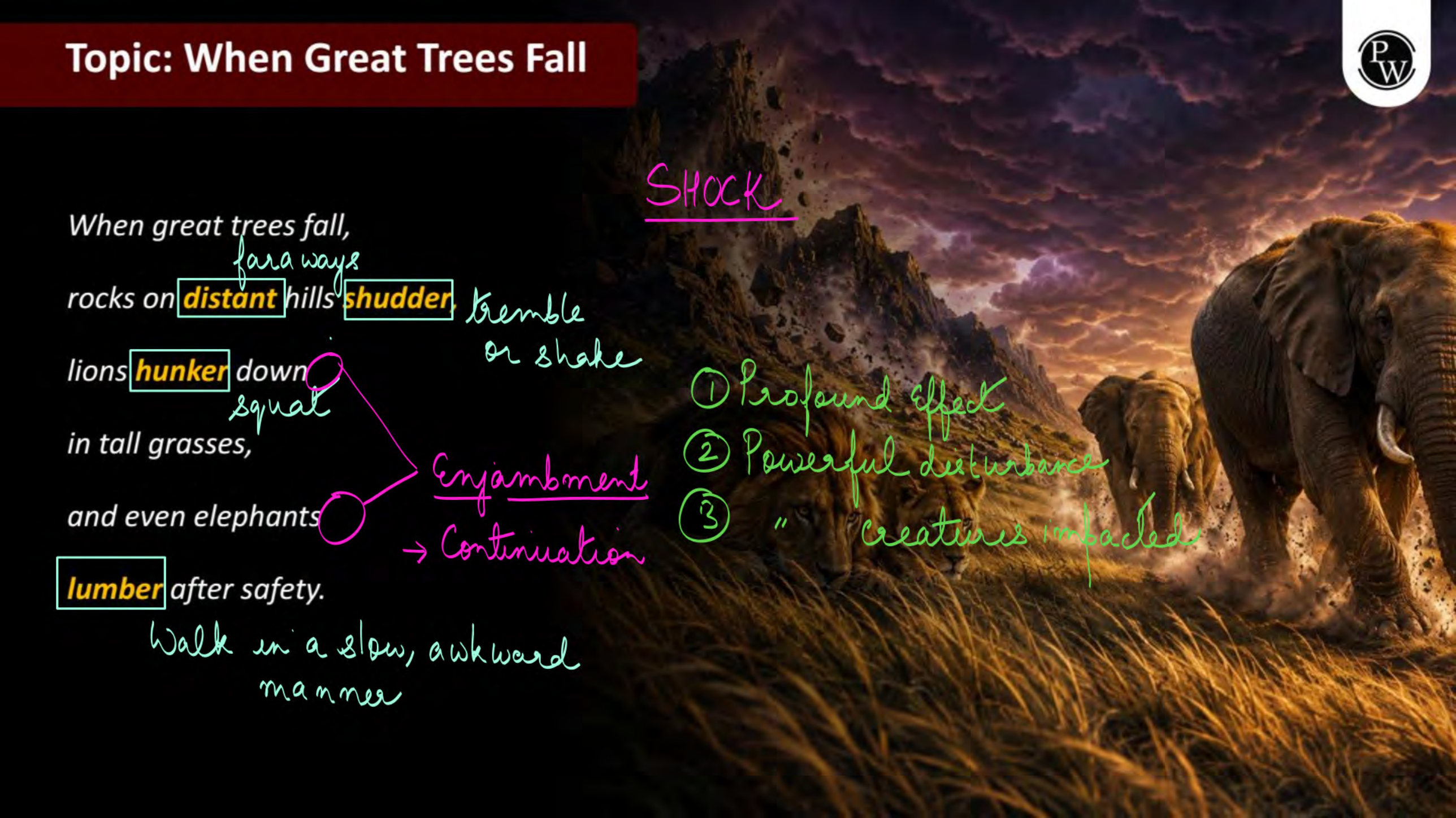
The poem **'When Great trees Fall'** by **Maya Angelou** is emotional as it raises a **similarity between nature and humans.**

The poet equates great trees with great men and wants to say that the loss of great men **from the earth is significant just like the destruction of an old tree destabilizes equilibrium of the forest.**

The poem ends on a positive and comforting note that **one can console oneself that once such great men existed around them.** We can get inspiration from their lives and aim to be great like them.



Topic: When Great Trees Fall



SHOCK

When great trees fall,

rocks on **distant** (faraways) hills **shudder** (tremble or shake),

lions **hunker** (squat) down

in tall grasses,

and even elephants

lumber (walk in a slow, awkward manner) after safety.

Enjambment → Continuation

① Profound effect
② Powerful disturbance
③ " creatures impacted

Topic: When Great Trees Fall

When great trees fall

in forests,

small things **recoil** *into silence,*

their senses

eroded *beyond fear.*

deteriorated

Shrink

SHOCK

① Ripple effect of loss in nature
② Their senses stop working
Overwhelmed
③ Flinch back in fear
④ Fear of loss impacts the small and ordinary creatures



Topic: When Great Trees Fall

When great souls die,

the air around us becomes

light, ***rare, sterile.***

We breathe, ***briefly.***

Our eyes, briefly,

see with

a ***hurtful clarity.***

not in an adequate quantity

acute clarity
Clarity which is painful

REALISATION

1. Emotionally shaken
2. Unable to breathe
3. Inadequate air
4. The air lacks vitality
1. Understanding which is very painful



Topic: MCQ

What does *"a hurtful clarity"* suggest?

A) A painful understanding of loss

B) A clear view of the future

C) An understanding of reality

D) A clarity of speech

Topic: When Great Trees Fall

Our memory, suddenly sharpened,

examines,

***gnaws on** kind words*

unsaid,

promised walks

never taken.

REGRET

① Continues to remind us painfully
② Regret



Topic: When Great Trees Fall

Great souls die and
perception tied
our reality, bound to

them, takes leave of us. departs

Our souls,

dependent upon their

nurture, Care and nourishement

now shrink, wizened. shrunk or shrivelled

REALISATION - CHANGED

Reality changes
Lack of nourishement
Feel smaller



Topic: MCQ

What does the word *"Wizened"* mean in the context of the poem?

A) Strengthened

B) Ignorant

C) Shrivelled or wrinkled with age

D) Blooming

Topic: When Great Trees Fall

Our minds, formed

and informed by their

radiance, fall away.

We are not so much maddened

as reduced to the unutterable ignorance of

dark, cold

caves.

Guiding light

IGNORANCE AND CONFUSION

① Lack of guidance

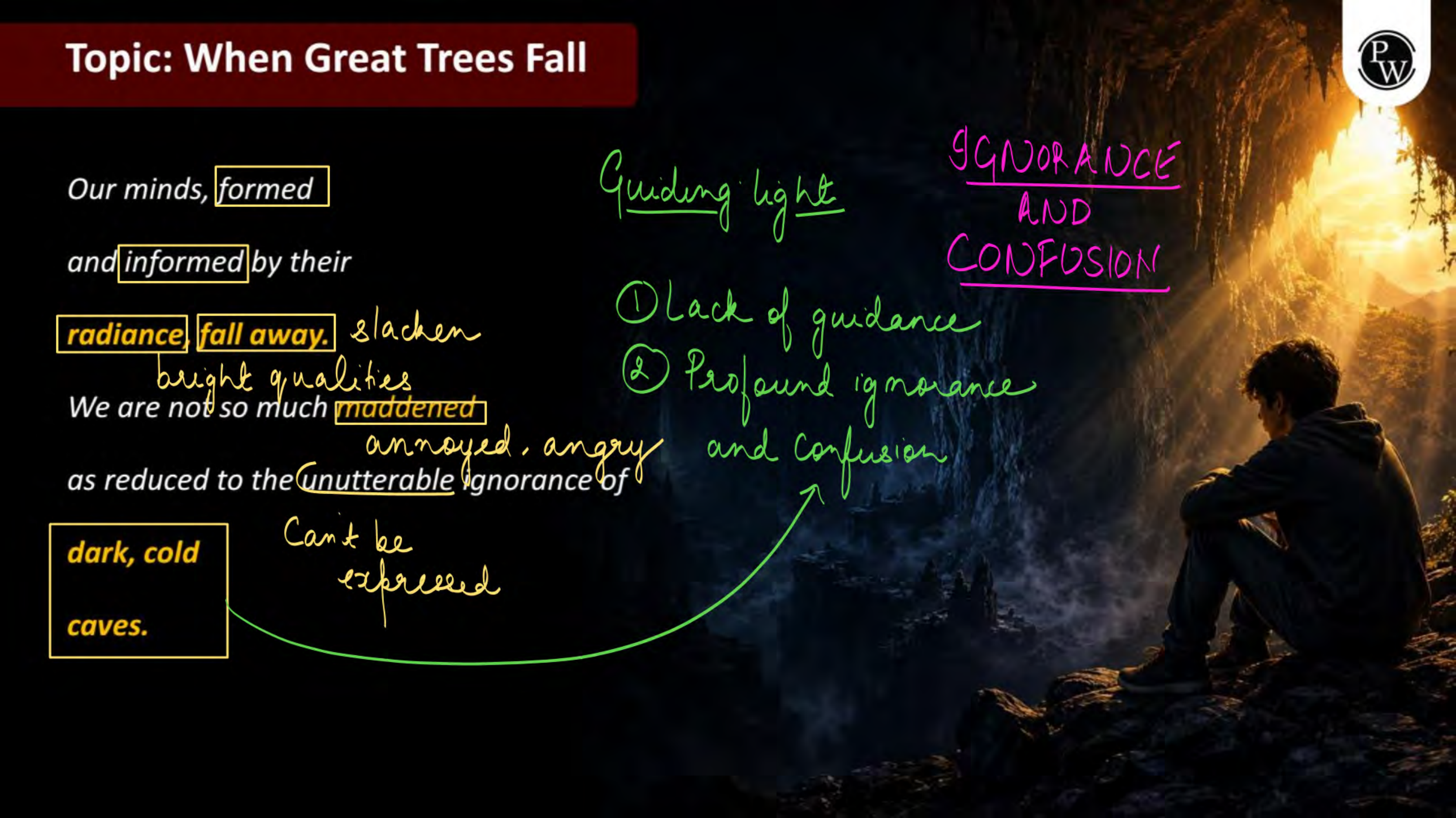
② Profound ignorance and confusion

slacken

bright qualities

annoyed, angry

Can't be expressed



Topic: MCQ

The phrase *'dark cold, caves'* symbolises _____ in the poem.

A) cheerfulness (Happiness)

B) depth of mind

C) despair (sadness, sorrow)

D) ignorance

Topic: When Great Trees Fall

And when great souls die,

after a period peace ***blooms,***

slowly and always

irregularly. Spaces fill

with a kind of

soothing electric vibration.

ACCEPTANCE

HEALING

① Healing and comforting energy



Topic: When Great Trees Fall

*Our senses, **restored**, never*

to be the same, whisper to us.

They existed. They existed.

We can be. Be and be

better. For they existed.

Eroded → Restored

INSIPIRATION

1. Reminded
2. Motivated / inspired
3. Strive to become better
4. Honouring their memory and legacy



Topic: MCQ

What happens to our senses when great men die?

Initially

A) they work better

eroded → restored

B) they remain normal

C) they stop working

eroded

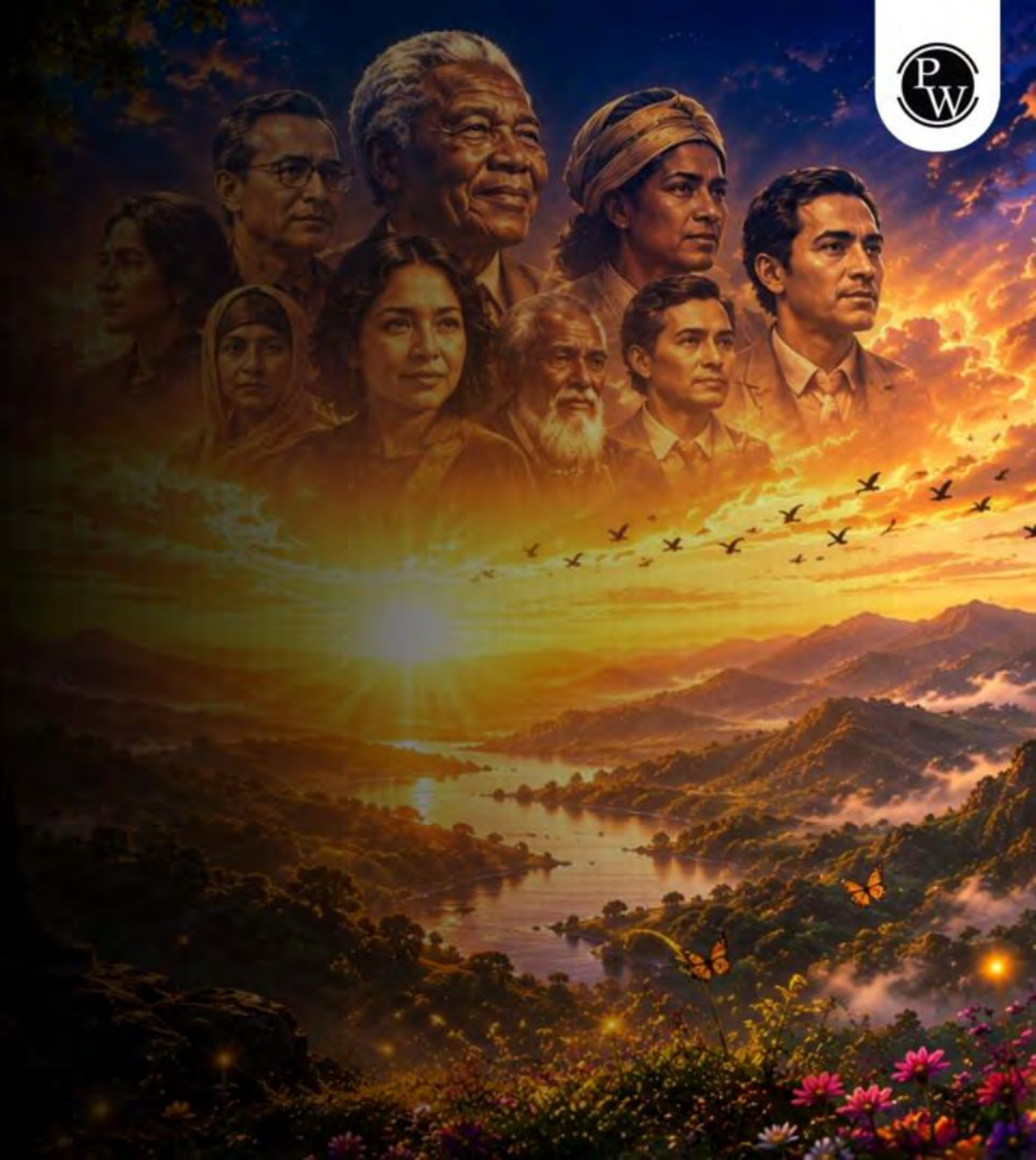
D) not mentioned

Topic: Theme

Important Themes of the Poem:

1. Death and Loss
2. Grief and Mourning
3. Influence and Legacy
4. Healing and Renewal
5. Memory and Acknowledgement

HW



Topic: Poetic Device

1. **Extended metaphor** - When an indirect comparison between the quality of two things is seen throughout a poem.

   Trees have been compared to **men**.

2. **Enjambment** - When the same sentence continues to the next line without the use of punctuation mark at the end of the line

3. **Alliteration** - the repetition of a consonant sound at the start of two or more consecutive words.

   Breathe, **b**riefly **M**uch **m**addened

Topic: Poetic Device

4. **Repetition** - the repeated use of a sentence or a word to emphasize on it

When great trees fall

When great souls die

They existed, they existed

Be and be

Emphasise

PYQs

&

SPQs

Topic: PYQ 2026

The *mood* in the poem, *'When Great Trees Fall'*, moves from_____

A) Hurt to wonder

B) Calm to distress

C) Hope to despair

D) Fear to hope

Topic: PYQ 2025

Select the option that shows the correct relationship between Statements (1) and (2) from Maya Angelou's poem, *'When Great Trees Fall':*

Statement 1: When great trees fall, the world is left permanently unstable.
Statement 2: In the poem, the natural world is depicted as reacting with fear and uncertainty when great trees fall.

(a) (1) is false, but (2) is true.
(b) Both (1) and (2) are false.
(c) (1) is true, but (2) is false.
(d) Both (1) and (2) are true.

Topic: SPQ 2027

(ix) Select the option that shows the correct relationship between Statements I and II from Maya Angelou's poem, *'When Great Trees Fall'*:

Statement I: When great trees fall, the world is left permanently unstable.

Statement II: In the poem, the natural world is depicted as reacting with fear and uncertainty when great trees fall.

Same as PYQ 2025

(a) Both the statements are true.

(b) Both the statements are false.

(c) Statement I is true, but statement II is false.

(d) Statement I is false, but statement II is true.

[Understanding]

Topic: SPQ 2025

The theme of Maya Angelou's poem *When Great Trees Fall* is:

(a) the impact of the death of a loved one on those left behind

(b) the effect of felling trees on the environment

(c) how the death of trees affects humanity

(d) the impact of natural calamities on a forest

Topic: PYQ 2026

Q. The poem was directly tested in the 2026 English Literature Paper 2. The extract was:

"When great trees fall,
rocks on distant hills shudder,
lions hunker down
in tall grasses,
and even elephants
lumber after safety."

Topic: PYQ 2026

I. What ***three*** images from the natural world does Angelou use to describe the effect of great trees falling? [3]

II. Angelou compares great trees to great souls. Mention ***two*** ways in which this comparison is appropriate. What is the ***mood*** created by the lines in the extract? [3]

III. What words does the poet use to describe the condition of the air around us when great souls die? What ***feeling*** is being expressed in the line, "We breathe, briefly"? [3]

IV. What, according to the poet, are the two things we remember ***and*** regret when a great soul dies? What happens to ***our*** souls when great souls die? [3]

V. "Angelou's poem is about the lasting influence of great souls." Explain the statement briefly. What aspect of the poem appeals to you? Give ***one*** reason for your response. [4]

Topic: Competency Based

#Q. Which of the following is NOT a characteristic of a 'great soul'?

(A) nurtures nourish

(B) shrinks those who are left behind

(C) radiant → bright qualities

(D) informs

Topic: Competency Based

#Q. Select the option that shows the correct relationship between the two given statements:

Statement I: *The falling of a great tree shocks both big and small creatures.* True

Statement II: *The death of a great person maddens their loved ones.* → False

we are not so much maddened as reduced

(A) Statement I is true, Statement II is false.

(B) Statement I is false, and Statement II is true.

a comparision

(C) Statement I is an analogy for Statement II.

(D) Statement I is the reason for Statement II.

Topic: Competency Based

#Q. The five stages of grief are described as shock, anger, bargaining, depression and acceptance. Which of these stages is expressed in the following lines?

"And when great souls die,
after a period peace blooms,"

(A) shock

(B) anger

(C) depression

(D) acceptance

HW

Topic: Competency Based

#Q. The central idea of Angelou's poem When Great Trees Fall is that_____.

(A) when a gigantic tree falls, it affects all the trees in the jungle.

(B) the death of an ancient tree disturbs all the animals in the jungle.

(C) the impact of the death of a loved one on those struggling to cope with the loss.

(D) life will never be the same after the loss of a loved one.

Topic: MCQ

Which extended metaphor is used in the poem?

A) the deaths of great men

B) the falling of great trees

C) nature

D) big and small animals

Topic: MCQ

Which positive event happens when great men die?

A) Our senses are benumbed.

B) Our memory is suddenly sharpened.

C) We feel sorry for ourselves.

D) We feel pity for great men.

Topic: MCQ

Which of these statements is NOT true ?

A) When great trees fall the rocks on distant hills shudder.

B) When great trees fall small animals do not bother.

C) The falling of great trees causes ripples for miles.

D) We should try to be better than we are.

Topic: MCQ

Which figure of speech is used in the line *'When Great Trees Fall'*?

A) simile

B) personification

C) metaphor

D) alliteration

Topic: MCQ

Which figure of speech has been used in the following line –

'After a period peace blooms'

A) simile

B) personification

C) repetition

D) alliteration

Topic : Questions

Q. **Read the extract given below and answer the questions that follow:**

When great trees fall
in forests,
small things recoil into silence,
their senses
eroded beyond fear.

Topic : Questions

Q. What does the fall of great trees symbolise in the poem?

Ans.

Q. What happens to big animals when great trees fall?

Ans.

Q. What happens to small things when great trees fall?

Ans.

Topic : Questions

Q.Explain the meaning of *'Their senses / eroded beyond fear'.*

Ans.

Q.When great men die, what kind of '*clarity*' do we have all of a sudden?

Ans.

Topic : Questions

Q. **Read the extract given below and answer the questions that follow:**

When great souls die,
the air around us becomes
light, rare, sterile.
We breathe, briefly.
Our eyes, briefly,
see with
a hurtful clarity.

Topic : Questions

Q. What image from the world of nature has been used earlier in the context?

Ans. falling of great trees

Q. What happens when great trees fall?

Ans. The rocks tremble, lions hide behind grass and elephants run to safer places. The smaller animals become silent and go back into their hiding places.

Q. *'We breathe, briefly'*. What does the poet mean by this?

Ans. We are uncomfortable and take shallow breaths.

Topic : Questions

Q. **Read the extract given below and answer the questions that follow:**

Our senses, restored, never
to be the same, whisper to us,
They existed. They existed.
We can be. Be and be
better. For they existed.



Topic : Questions

Q. How do we feel when persons attached to us die?

Ans. After the initial period of pain, there is peace and their great lives inspire us.

Q. When do we feel at peace when great souls die?

Ans.

HW

Q. Why do our sense never achieve the former state of normalcy after the death of great souls?

Ans. They change due to the experience of losing a loved one which has caused pain and sadness.

Topic : Questions

Q. What is the significance of the repetition of words in Lines 3-4?

Ans. To emphasize on the importance of being great like those great souls.

Q. The ending of the poem is quite positive. How?

Ans. It inspires us to become great.

ICSE
Questions &
Concept Bank

Solutions
(HW)
Pg 20 - 27

→ By Nupur Sharma


Thank You!